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Where Strategy meets the Market

Why a clear go-to-market model is essential to turning strategic ambitions into results.

Strategy only becomes real in the market

Companies have become extraordinarily sophisticated at developing strategies. Considerable time and resources are devoted to market research, competitor analysis, consumer insights, product portfolio reviews and assessments of geographies, channels and customers.

Financial targets are established to express the ambitions of the business. Detailed presentations explain where future growth will come from and how revenues and margins are expected to develop.

Yet companies sometimes remain surprisingly mediocre at translating those ambitions into execution. Perhaps this is because strategy development is often treated as an intellectual exercise, while execution is considered something that follows afterwards. But execution is not simply the implementation phase of strategy. **The ability to execute should influence the strategic choices themselves.**

A business strategy should define where a company chooses to compete and how it intends to win. A go-to-market model translates those choices into customers, channels, value propositions, commercial capabilities—and ultimately revenue. Without that translation, strategy may remain little more than ambition.

A clear **go-to-market model** should provide answers to **five fundamental questions**:

1. Which customers are we choosing to serve?
2. What problem are we solving for them?
3. Why should they choose us rather than an alternative?
4. Through which channels and commercial model will we reach them?
5. What capabilities must we build to deliver that promise consistently?

These questions may appear straightforward. Answering them clearly—and accepting the consequences of those answers—is considerably more difficult.

Turning strategic choices into a go-to-market model

In one of the businesses I previously led, we developed a new European strategy. The team did an excellent job collecting and analysing the information required to define the future direction of the business. We examined markets, product portfolios, channels, customers and the resources required to execute the plan. But the real breakthrough came when we moved beyond analysis and began making choices.

Until then, individual countries largely managed their own product portfolios and customer priorities. This had created considerable complexity and limited our ability to leverage the scale and capabilities of the wider European business.

We decided to standardize a large part of our product and customer/channel priorities through clear product-and-channel matrices. We discontinued parts of the existing assortment, invested in new products and technologies, and moved from a predominantly country-based sales structure to a European channel-based approach. Leaders were given responsibility across countries for specific channels and product categories.

These were not simply organizational adjustments. They fundamentally changed how the business would compete and **how resources would be allocated**.

The strategy was becoming real.

Every strategic choice has consequences

The new model placed much greater emphasis on innovation, consumer insights and the relevance of our products to specific customers and channels. It required a different level of coordination between Sales, Marketing and R&D—and, in some roles, different capabilities.

This led us to the **most difficult part of the transformation**: determining whether we had the right people in the right roles to deliver the strategy. We needed to onboard new capabilities while developing existing team members wherever possible. At the same time, we had to acknowledge that not every role—and not every individual—would fit the requirements of the new model. These were difficult decisions. They affected colleagues who had contributed to the business and deserved to be treated with fairness and respect. But avoiding those decisions would have created a strategy that looked convincing on paper while leaving the organization largely unchanged.

Talent decisions are therefore not a secondary HR workstream within strategy execution. They are among its most important—and most demanding—elements.

From ambition to organizational commitment

A credible strategy is not defined by the quality of its analysis or the attractiveness of its financial projections. It is defined by the clarity of the choices it makes and by the willingness of the organization to act on their consequences.

Which markets will we prioritize—and which will we not? Which customers and channels will receive greater attention? Which products will we invest in, and which will we discontinue? What capabilities must be strengthened? And are we genuinely prepared to align our organization and talent with those choices?

The go-to-market model is **where strategic ambition encounters commercial reality**. It is also where leaders discover whether they have developed a genuine strategy—or simply described a desirable future. So perhaps the questions worth asking are:

- Is our go-to-market model clear enough to guide everyday commercial decisions?
- Have we made genuine choices, or are we still trying to serve every market, customer and channel?
- Does our organization possess the capabilities required to deliver the strategy?
- And are we prepared to make the difficult decisions that execution inevitably demands?